



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-152
FIRST IN COUNCIL
August 3, 2026

COUNCILLOR NOLAN
COUNCILLOR SOBRINHO-WHEELER
COUNCILLOR AL-ZUBI
MAYOR SIDDIQUI

- WHEREAS: Housing costs are often burdensomely high for Cambridge residents, but energy efficiency and electrification upgrades can significantly reduce these costs; and
- WHEREAS: Cambridge has included energy upgrades at points of transition in climate plans for more than a decade, including the [Net Zero Action Plan](#) adopted by the City Council in 2015; and
- WHEREAS: For large commercial and industrial buildings, Cambridge already has ambitious emissions reductions policies, such as the Building Energy Use Disclosure Ordinance (BEUDO); and
- WHEREAS: Energy efficiency and electrification upgrades for residential buildings are a goal of the City, and one way to advance that goal is by incentivizing energy audits, which provide clear recommendations on possible actions to take; and
- WHEREAS: In addition to potentially reducing the cost of housing, decarbonization of dwelling units can achieve health benefits for Cambridge residents; and
- WHEREAS: Emissions from one-to-four-family residences alone account for approximately 8% of total emissions in Cambridge, and all residential buildings account for approximately 20% of total emissions in Cambridge; and
- WHEREAS: Residents who seek to address citywide emissions, as well as their own individual emissions, have one main avenue for direct action and impact, which is their own household energy footprint; and
- WHEREAS: Residents in one-to-four unit buildings can lower their household emissions by taking advantage of energy-saving programs, including free energy audits available through MassSAVE; and
- WHEREAS: The time a building is sold is an optimal moment to make energy efficiency upgrades; and
- WHEREAS: There is interest in helping renters in addition to homeowners, by incentivizing landlords to install energy upgrades that generate energy savings for renters; and

- WHEREAS: Plans adopted by the City Council, including Net Zero Action Plans and the Climate Crisis Working Group report, recommended doing more to engage residential properties in climate action, and Cambridge could follow the lead of cities such as Austin, Texas, which for more than a decade has required energy audits upon the sale of all buildings, including residential and commercial; and
- WHEREAS: Buyers of, and renters in, residential buildings should be informed about a building's energy efficiency, its energy use requirements, and its expected utility operating costs; and
- WHEREAS: [Electrify Cambridge](#) provides residents and property owners with free support for home energy and efficiency upgrades; now therefore be it
- ORDERED That the Health and Environment Committee hold a public hearing on the recommendations from past City Council and City adopted climate plans that have yet to be enacted, beginning with discussion of a possible requirement for an energy audit at the time of sale, along the same lines as [Austin, Texas](#); [Portland, Oregon](#); [Ann Arbor, Michigan](#); and [Berkeley, California](#), and including how to address energy costs with renters and landlords; and be it further
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to direct the appropriate staff to work with the Committee to discuss a time-of-sale energy audit and review possible ordinance language, for potential adoption after deliberation and refinement; and be it further
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to direct appropriate City staff to work with the Committee to conduct outreach to all stakeholders, including homeowners, condo owners, realtors, MassSave, and any other relevant group, as part of this effort.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-



Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

That the City Manager is requested to direct the appropriate staff to work with the Health and Environment Committee to discuss a time-of-sale energy audit and review possible ordinance language, for potential adoption after deliberation and refinement.